



(CLOCKWISE FROM TOP) NEPAL'S PRACHANDA, BHUTAN'S THINLEY AND BANGLADESH'S HASINA



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AFP

Pakistan when General Pervez Musharraf's hold over the presidency was weakening. Instead of wasting time squabbling over the fine print of the deal, India could have turned the goodwill that George Bush had for India into securing more than just nuclear trade for us. Or, with China emerging as India's largest trading partner, built more leverage with it to ensure that Pakistan could not take Chinese support for granted every time India had an argument with it. So now when confronted with a Pakistan in total denial, India has realised the limits of its power and the folly of not having built a national

consensus over its foreign policy that protected the nation's interest even as it allowed for political debate.

Though 2008 did end on a gloomy note for Indian diplomacy, there were other heartening trends. Momentous changes were happening around the neighbourhood. In Nepal, much to India's relief, democracy finally prevailed with the Maoists, led by its one-time revolutionary Pushpa Kamal Dahal or Prachanda, emerging as prime minister. There were still plenty of concerns though, including that of disarming the Maoists' army. In Bhutan, there was a more peaceful transition with the royalty gracefully

yielding power and holding the first democratic election in the former kingdom. In Bangladesh, which was under a spell of disguised army rule, democracy made a strong comeback with the Awami League headed by Sheikh Hasina gaining a landslide victory. Hasina is expected to be friendlier to India than her uncooperative predecessor Khaleda Zia, bringing hope that Bangladesh would now control the extreme religious elements. In Pakistan too, democracy returned with a shaky coalition headed by Asif Zardari taking charge though that doesn't seem to have helped India much. In Sri Lanka, as Mahinda Rajapakse waged a decisive battle against the LTTE, India gave its tacit support but made it clear that it was not at the cost of greater devolution of powers to the Tamil minority.

The constraints of India's power also showed up when our efforts to become a major player in the ASEAN groupings didn't bear much fruit despite several summits. A Free Trade Agreement, in the works for years, is yet to be signed between India and ASEAN.

**DEMOCRATIC REGIMES
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